Nancy visited one 13 year old boy and his heart beat went from 70 to 130. Tuesday night was the best for sleeping. All the way through until 5 A.M. . . .”

By Wednesday, July 17, I felt better, although I still knew I’d been through something. George Bush and Don Regan and other White House staffers came to the hospital to discuss our latest battles with Congress over the budget. Then, in the next entry in my diary, unaware at the time where it would lead to, I recorded an event that was to mark the beginning of what became known as the Iran-Contra affair:

“Miracle of miracles,” I wrote, “I had my first food by mouth. A cup of tea. I’m waiting to see what happens. By evening I repeated that menu with good results. The doctor says maybe he’ll take the feeding tube out tomorrow. Some strange soundings are coming from some Iranians. Bud M. will be here tomorrow to talk about it. It could be a breakthrough on getting our seven kidnap victims back. Evidently the Iranian economy is disintegrating fast under the strain of war.”

Even now, I’m still a little annoyed at how my operation was reported. “The president has cancer,” they wrote. In fact, the president *had* cancer. Yes, doctors found an object in my body that was cancerous. But they removed it, and, because they couldn’t take any chances that malignant cells might have penetrated beyond the polyp, they also took out a portion of my intestine. But they learned that no cancer cells had entered the rest of my body at all; there was no cancer beyond the polyp, and it was removed. Yes, it was major surgery, but it was a minor situation.

It happened again barely ten days later, shortly after I left Bethesda.

For years, I had had a tiny bump on my nose that I thought was a pimple. When I got home from the hospital, it was a little more inflamed than usual. I blamed it on